

Israel's Wisdom Among Its Neighbors

Proverbs sits beside Egyptian instruction. Job and Ecclesiastes answer Babylonian despair. Borrowed forms, and a different God inside them.

THE SETTING

Israel Was Not the Only Wise Nation

Somewhere we picked up the assumption that inspiration means isolation, that if the Bible is the word of God it must owe nothing to anyone. So it surprises people to learn that Israel's wisdom literature sits inside an international conversation that had been running for many centuries before Solomon.

Egypt produced instructions, a father's counsel to a son, for over a thousand years. Mesopotamia produced proverbs, fables, and anguished dialogues about suffering. The Old Testament itself says Solomon's wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the children of the east country, and all the wisdom of Egypt. The compliment only works if the east and Egypt had real wisdom to excel.

Proverbs even names foreign voices. The words of Agur. The words of king Lemuel, which his mother taught him. Neither is an Israelite name. The book of the covenant people opens its doors to outside wisdom and is not nervous about it. We are the nervous ones, and our nervousness says more about our doctrine of inspiration than about theirs.

EGYPT

Thirty Sayings and an Egyptian Scribe

The sharpest case is the Instruction of Amenemope, an Egyptian text from the late New Kingdom, composed somewhere around 1300 to 1100 BC and preserved on a papyrus now in the British Museum. Amenemope counsels his son in thirty numbered chapters. Do not move the boundary stones of the widow. Do not wear yourself out chasing riches, for wealth makes itself wings like geese and flies to the sky.

Now read Proverbs 22:17 through 24:22. Incline thine ear, and hear the words of the wise. Remove not the old landmark. Riches certainly make themselves wings, they fly away as an eagle toward heaven. And in 22:20 the Hebrew can be read, have I not written to thee thirty sayings. Most scholars conclude that the editors of Proverbs knew Amenemope, or a tradition shared with it, and worked the material into

Scripture under a new purpose, stated plainly in the text, that thy trust may be in the LORD.

Notice what the biblical editors did not do. They did not hide the connection or launder the source. They took up the wisdom, set it under the fear of the LORD, and called it what it had become. The word of God is not afraid of where its words have been.

BABYLON

The Sufferer Who Gets an Answer

Mesopotamia also knew that devout people suffer, and it wrote about the problem with real anguish. A poem scholars nickname the Babylonian Job, Ludlul bel nemeqi, I will praise the lord of wisdom, follows a pious man abandoned by his god, eaten by disease, mocked by his city, unable to discover what he did wrong. The Babylonian Theodicy stages a long debate between a sufferer and his orthodox friend. Parts of these texts sound startlingly like the speeches of Job.

But watch where they end. The sufferer in Ludlul never learns why he suffered. He concludes that the will of the gods is past finding out, and he is finally restored by Marduk through the ritual system. The machinery is appeased. No one is addressed.

Job ends somewhere else entirely. God speaks. Out of the whirlwind, in person, at length. Job receives no explanation of his suffering, and the book refuses to invent one. But he receives the one thing the Babylonian sufferer never gets, the presence and voice of God himself, along with the verdict that his friends and their tidy retribution theology had not spoken rightly. The difference between Job and Babylon is not the honesty of the pain. It is whether anyone answers.

GILGAMESH

Same Table. Different Host.

Ecclesiastes has its ancient cousins too. In the Epic of Gilgamesh, the hero, terrified of death after losing his friend, meets a tavern keeper named Siduri who tells him to stop chasing immortality. Fill your belly. Make merry by day and by night. Cherish the child who holds your hand, and let your wife delight in your embrace, for this is the task of mankind. The gods kept life for themselves.

Qoheleth says something almost identical. Eat thy bread with joy, and drink thy wine with a merry heart. Live joyfully with the wife whom thou lovest all the days of thy vanishing life. The form is the same, and the unflinching honesty about death is the same. Ecclesiastes refuses to pretend any more than Gilgamesh does.

The frame is not the same. For Siduri, the feast is the consolation prize of beings the gods shut out. For Ecclesiastes, the bread and the wine and the marriage are the gift of God, received from his hand under his judgment, with eternity set in the human heart even when we cannot trace his work. Same table.

Different host.

THE VERDICT

Borrowed Form, Converted Content

What do we do with all of this. Two things, and they hold together.

First, common grace. Wisdom is built into the grain of creation, and Egyptian scribes and Babylonian poets read that grain truly at many points, because they were image-bearers studying a real world. Scripture is not threatened by truth found outside Israel. Proverbs absorbs it without apology. If God's world is one world, we should expect a pagan farmer to know real things about diligence, and a pagan father to know real things about sons.

Second, inspiration. The Spirit did not dictate into a vacuum. He took up forms that already existed, the instruction, the dialogue, the proverb, and converted their content around the fear of the LORD, the covenant God who answers from whirlwinds and hosts the feast. Borrowed form, transformed substance. That is not a defect in Scripture. It is how the Word has always come, all the way down to a manger in an occupied province.

This pattern should change how we hold our Bibles and how we treat our neighbors. The wisdom of the nations was real, and it was not enough. It still is, and it still is not.

KEY TEXTS

Proverbs 22:17-21

Job 38:1-7

Ecclesiastes 9:7-10

SOURCES

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The Wisdom of Proverbs, Job and Ecclesiastes — Derek Kidner

The Bible Among the Myths — John N. Oswalt